fact of his death – that is to say, the commitment to which that death attests'.[12] As she explains, 'what makes Bhagat Singh so compelling for people of varied hues in India is precisely his passion, manifested in his embrace of death'.[13] Yet, 'Bhagat Singh's relation to death cannot be exhausted by the phrase "dying for the nation" although that is often how he is remembered today'.[14] The 'centrality of death' to Bhagat Singh's outlook is linked to a wider 'imagination and other elements such as excessive love, delirium (*junoon*), and the explosive destructiveness and generosity of youth'.[15] In this way, '[t]he dissolution of the self in love, in this language, allegorizes the death-in-struggle of a committed political actor'.[16]

This is also why Bhagat Singh was scornful of the sort of shallow-minded Indian mysticism that induces spasms of uncontrolled sentimentalism and self-pity, emphasizing the need for rationalism, by pointing out that '[w]e become pitiable and ridiculous when we imbibe an unreasoned mysticism in our life without any natural or substantial basis'. That, he reminds Sukhdev at the time when he was contemplating suicide, is to betray the cause of the revolutionary so that '[p]eople like us, who are proud to be revolutionary in every sense, should always be prepared to bear all the difficulties, anxieties, pain and suffering which we invite upon ourselves by the struggles initiated by us and for which we call ourselves revolutionary'. In fact, appeals to God are of no avail in times like this. In the same letter to Sukhdev, Bhagat Singh is not only disarmingly frank but utterly compelling in his penetrating logic when he exclaims, 'We do not believe in God, hell and heaven, punishment and rewards, that is in any Godly accounting of human life. Therefore, we must think of life and death on materialist lines.'[17]

It is precisely this attitude to death which Moffat finds alluring in his study because it is 'not just any death' but one involving 'a spectacular self-sacrifice' that is openly 'invited and embraced by the revolutionary'.[18] When Bhagat Singh scolds Sukhdev, he does so in terms which remind him that '[t]o die in a struggle like this is an ideal death' and that 'those of us who are certain to get the death sentence should wait patiently for the day when this sentence would be pronounced, after which they will be hanged'.